situation, by raising Persians to high honours and by incorporating shaikhzadas and Rajputs into the nobility. The Turani element, dangerous and subversive, would be consistently undermined, the traditions and the culture they represented now a desultory reminder of a past that would no longer be considered relevant.

Nor was the old Turani nobility the only danger to the young Padshah and his empire. Indeed the entire kingdom was circled by warlords, pretenders, chieftains, and kings:

> Powerful Afghan chiefs held considerable territory from the central Ganges valley through Bihar to Bengal, and in Malwa. Rajput lineages dominated Rajasthan, while further south lay the rich and powerful state of Gujarat. For many disaffected parties uprooted by the return of Mughal power, the sultanate of Gujarat offered an attractive refuge and source of patronage.

In the next few years Akbar would confront all these dangers—Malwa, Gujarat, Rajasthan, Bihar, and Bengal. Akbar's empire, at this time, was made up of all the lands that Babur had once ruled, and that Humayun had lost:

> A broad band of land across the sweep of the Indo-Gangetic plain, from Afghanistan to the eastern border of modern Uttar Pradesh. The empire was still relatively small, only about a third of what it would be at the end of Akbar's reign, though it was already the largest and the most powerful state in the subcontinent, as India was at this time fragmented into over twenty kingdoms.

But even as he was beginning to turn his attention towards taming the capricious and sometimes violent wills of his men, there were times when Akbar was still a reckless twenty-year-old, and opaque even to himself. One day in Agra, having had a few cups of wine, Akbar went to the polo field he had constructed outside the Agra Fort to watch his elephants fight. The elephant Hawai, possibly Hemu's captured beast, who was noted for its 'choler, passionateness, fierceness and wickedness', was in a particular fury that day. Akbar jumped onto the enormous elephant and goaded it to fight the elephant Ranbagh, the 'Tiger in Battle'. The elephants shook their massive heads and crashed into each other, to the utter consternation of the retinue and onlookers, who stood by wailing and pleading with the young